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ACRC CONCERN

ACRC Concern: No. 02-17022026

Bakamla's 2045 Force Posture: Opportunities, Constraints, and the Real Market Test

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***Synopsis*:** Bakamla's 2045 force posture, often reduced to a headline figure of 274 vessels, should be read as a long-term capability signal, not a single procurement list. For industry, the most credible opportunities sit in the operational foundations: NMSS surveillance infrastructure, integration, interoperability, maintenance, training, and governance-ready support systems that sustain readiness.

Discussion

In early January 2026, public attention turned to Bakamla after national media reported that the agency was formulating its organizational and force posture through 2045, including an estimate that Indonesia might require around 274 vessels for maritime surveillance and patrol missions. The number immediately drew interest because it underscores a stark gap between ambition and today's limited fleet. Yet the deeper policy signal is not the vessel count itself. It is the state's apparent intention to move toward a more structured coast guard capability, something closer to a long-term institutional modernization project than a conventional procurement plan.

This distinction matters because maritime security modernization tends to fail when treated as a shopping list of platforms. A credible coast guard capability is built when vessels, sensors, communications, personnel, doctrine, and maintenance systems function as one coherent operational system. Put plainly, “more assets” does not automatically become “more capability.” The gap between the two is precisely where the real market opportunities lie, and where the largest commercial risks emerge.

The DPR’s signals reinforce this broader interpretation. In a hearing with DPR Commission I on January 19, 2026, the Commission reportedly emphasized acceleration of the National Maritime Security System (NMSS), stronger integration of maritime surveillance systems, improved coordination and interoperability across ministries and agencies, optimized patrol operations, and institutional strengthening of Bakamla through a maritime security legislative pathway. These are not shipyard-only messages. They point to operational foundations and governance clarity, both of which shape whether the market is truly bankable.

Posture is a horizon, not a tender

In policy language, posture is a long-horizon concept. It describes the capability an institution aims to build and the conditions needed to sustain it: basing support, human resources, operating procedures, maintenance discipline, and integrated surveillance. Under this logic, the figure of 274 vessels is better understood as an ideal requirement to close capability gaps gradually, not as a single consolidated acquisition to be executed at once.

For business actors, this framing is decisive. If the market is interpreted purely as “new hulls,” firms will gravitate toward shipbuilding competitions and underestimate the system components that determine operational outcomes. In many countries, serious coast guard development prioritizes sensor coverage, intelligence-led tasking, command-and-control, and readiness management. Those elements often deliver larger operational gains than simply adding patrol hours, especially across a maritime domain as large and diverse as Indonesia’s.

This is why the DPR’s emphasis on NMSS and interoperability deserves particular attention. It suggests a recognition that patrol effectiveness depends on detection and decision systems that cue vessels toward targets, rather than relying on routine patrol patterns that are expensive and not always well targeted. In practice, NMSS becomes the difference between “presence” and “precision.”

NMSS as the core market signal

NMSS is significant because it reframes maritime security as infrastructure. When Bakamla proposed additional funding in 2025 (reportedly around IDR 5.6 trillion) to develop NMSS across 35 locations (including radar, cameras, drones, and small patrol-support assets), the implication was clear: maritime security is being positioned as a networked system with recurring lifecycle requirements.

From an industry standpoint, NMSS is commercially attractive because it creates layered demand. It involves initial deployment, integration, and commissioning, followed by continuous sustainment: calibration, upgrades, component replacement, software maintenance, cybersecurity patching, operator training, and incident-response support. It also lends itself to outcome measurement (uptime, coverage, detection quality, response time) which can anchor procurement toward performance rather than ceremonial delivery.

At the same time, NMSS introduces a strict realism test. Many surveillance programs struggle not because the technology is inherently flawed, but because the operating environment and support ecosystem are underestimated. Indonesia’s coastal monitoring points include remote and harsh settings: humidity, salt corrosion, uneven power stability, difficult access, and logistical constraints. Systems that look impressive in product brochures can degrade quickly without climate resilience and reliable local support. For suppliers, this is not a minor technical footnote, it is the line between an operational asset and a stranded project.

Sensors: the life-cycle market, not a one-off sale

If NMSS develops across dozens of locations, the sensor segment may scale faster than large-vessel procurement in the short to medium term. Relevant needs include coastal radar, electro-optical/infrared cameras, AIS receivers, frequency monitoring systems, shipborne sensors, and potentially airborne sensors such as drones. Commercially, this cluster tends to have two phases: installation, then sustainment. The second phase is often more durable and profitable because it continues throughout the system’s operating life.

This is also where vendor credibility is tested. In security systems, the end user’s primary fear is not imperfection; it is unreliability. Long downtimes become operational vulnerabilities and political liabilities. Suppliers that cannot demonstrate field service capacity (technicians, spare parts, remote diagnostics, rapid response) are likely to be treated as operational risks rather than partners, regardless of how strong their brochures look.

A second issue is data compatibility. NMSS is a network; networks require standardized formats, secure interfaces, and clear governance rules. Vendors who lock data into closed formats may win early but face resistance later as interoperability becomes a political and operational requirement. Conversely, overly open architectures without strong security controls may be viewed as vulnerabilities. Bankable proposals usually sit in the middle: modular interoperability paired with verifiable cybersecurity and auditable access control.

Cybersecurity, in this setting, is not an optional add-on. Sensors are nodes in a network that can be jammed, spoofed, or compromised. Vendors need to explain hardening measures, audit logs, patch management, and incident response. As NMSS becomes a backbone of maritime governance, “secure-by-design” becomes part of bankability, not an afterthought.

Integration and command-and-control: where outcomes are decided

Across maritime capability development globally, integration is often the decisive segment. Integration includes command-and-control centers, data fusion, communications networks, and rules for cross-agency data exchange. It also includes less visible but crucial elements: tasking procedures, information classification protocols, and authority arrangements for who can access what data and under what conditions.

The DPR’s emphasis on integrating maritime surveillance systems and strengthening interoperability across ministries and agencies provides political legitimacy for investments in what connects the system together. For suppliers, this expands opportunities beyond one-time system building into recurring contracts: application maintenance, feature upgrades, managed services, cybersecurity monitoring, and operator training.

But integration carries the highest complexity risk. The first is scope creep: as users recognize new possibilities, requirements expand. Without firm boundaries and measurable indicators, vendors can be pulled into growing projects without proportional increases in contract value. The second is governance risk: Indonesia’s maritime space involves multiple agencies with different mandates, legacy systems, and institutional interests. A technically excellent solution can fail if data sharing rules are unclear or contested.

In such conditions, vendors often succeed not by offering the most advanced technology, but by offering a modular architecture that can be adopted incrementally. A phased approach reduces the risk of total failure, delivers proof of value early, and helps maintain stakeholder alignment. It also fits Indonesia’s reality: large-scale, multi-agency integration rarely works when designed as a single all-or-nothing leap.

Retrofitting existing assets: the practical entry point

While fleet expansion attracts headlines, retrofitting and modernizing existing vessels can deliver faster operational gains. Upgrading communications, sensors, and data integration on current assets improves readiness without the long lead times of new ship construction. Retrofits are also easier to package into smaller tenders, which can be commercially attractive and politically manageable. For suppliers, retrofit projects can function as a strategic entry path: demonstrate performance in Indonesian operating conditions, build trust, and establish after-sales networks that later become decisive when larger procurements emerge.

If Bakamla's posture is pursued seriously, maintenance is not a supporting activity; it is the foundation of operational readiness. MRO includes docking, engine overhaul, upkeep of navigation and communication systems, sensor calibration, spare-parts management, and mid-life upgrades. Over a 2045 horizon, lifecycle costs can exceed acquisition costs, making MRO one of the most strategic market segments.

MRO opportunities can expand even before fleet growth. Existing ships and emerging NMSS infrastructure require routine service, and NMSS across 35 locations will require periodic maintenance across distributed points. This segment lends itself to regional service provider networks, which can also strengthen local supply chains.

However, commercial risks are real: payment structures, spare parts availability, and facility constraints. If docking and workshop infrastructure is not adequate in required locations, vendors must invest early or build partnerships, raising fixed costs. In this segment, reputation is often the strongest commercial asset. Suppliers known as slow or unreliable can be sidelined informally even when formal contracts exist.

Training is similarly strategic. Modern coast guard development depends on replicable competence: ship operators, boarding teams, technicians, command-center operators, analysts, and joint procedures needed for interoperability. Training markets are large but often suffer from discontinuity. Firms seeking recurring revenue typically need training-of-trainers models, certified curricula, and training packages linked to specific systems such as NMSS.

The structural constraints behind "bankability"

Three structural constraints will shape whether the "2045 posture" becomes a reliable market. First is mandate and governance. The DPR's emphasis on strengthening Bakamla through a maritime security bill implies the institutional configuration remains fluid. Mandate evolution can shift platform preferences and system priorities, especially if the balance between shipping safety/SAR and law enforcement changes over time. Firms should avoid locking into assumptions that cannot survive legal and institutional change.

Second is fiscal discipline. The scale implied by NMSS investment and fleet expansion requires multi-year budgeting and continuity. Yet national budget priorities compete across sectors, and procurement is often split into smaller packages. Fragmentation can increase tendering costs, complicate integration, and make schedules more politically sensitive.

Third is interoperability politics. Interoperability requires data governance: ownership, access rights, standards, and cybersecurity rules. Closed solutions may face resistance, but overly open solutions without strong security controls may be treated as operational risks. Bankable proposals must treat interoperability and security as one combined requirement.

A final constraint is operational acceptance risk. Assets can be delivered, yet readiness can fail if training, documentation, spare parts, and maintenance infrastructure are not prepared. In maritime security procurement, reputations are shaped less by delivery ceremonies than by readiness outcomes months after commissioning.

Market entry strategies: positioning for a five-to-ten-year game

For firms, the central strategic question is not "how many vessels will be purchased?" but "in which capability clusters can a durable position be built over five to ten years?" The headline figure of 274 is a narrative anchor, but the DPR's operational emphasis suggests the market will be shaped by NMSS development, integration, interoperability, and institutional strengthening.

Several implications follow. Firms need role clarity: whether they aim to be shipbuilders, subsystem suppliers, integrators, or service providers. They need operational partnerships rather than purely formal ones. Partnerships that can actually deliver field support, docking, spares logistics, and rapid response across Indonesia's geography. They need to sell lifecycle assurance rather than products, because readiness and uptime will be the real outputs that matter as oversight tightens. And they need to treat interoperability and cybersecurity as core design commitments from the beginning, because these will be political and operational requirements, not optional features.

For domestic firms, the most credible entry path often begins in clusters that reward local presence: MRO, sensor installation and sustainment, and integration subcontracting, with shipyards strongest when they pair platforms with disciplined after-sales support. For foreign firms, defensible entry often lies in difficult-to-substitute technologies (high-performance sensors, secure communications, cybersecurity, data fusion) paired with credible sustainability commitments: local support, knowledge transfer, compliance readiness, and operational responsiveness.

Conclusion

The figure of "274 ships by 2045" should be interpreted as a posture signal and long-term policy direction rather than a procurement list to be executed in one sweep. It reflects a real capability gap, but the most immediate and bankable opportunities lie in building the foundations of modern maritime security: NMSS, system integration, secure communications, vessel retrofits, human resource development, and MRO capacity.

This is also where the biggest risks concentrate. Bakamla's mandate remains fluid, legislative developments can reshape requirements, large investments face fiscal competition and procurement fragmentation, and interoperability introduces governance complexity that must be managed through secure data rules and auditable access arrangements.

What follows is a practical implication for public discussion: the market question is less about whether 274 vessels will ever be purchased and more about whether Indonesia can build the governance, infrastructure, and maintenance discipline that makes any long-horizon posture real. If that is the real test, then Indonesia's next debate should be more specific than the headline. How should Bakamla's coast guard mandate be defined in law, and what indicators would demonstrate it functions as a coherent coast guard rather than one actor among many maritime agencies?

The next questions would be: What sequencing is most realistic (NMSS and integration first, fleet expansion first, or a balanced approach) and what evidence should guide that choice beyond institutional preferences? If NMSS is treated as the backbone of capability, then what performance metrics should Indonesia use to evaluate it (coverage, uptime, detection accuracy, response time, interdiction outcomes, or a composite readiness index) and who should be tasked to validate those metrics credibly? If fleet growth eventually accelerates, how should vessel class standardization be designed early to avoid the familiar readiness decline driven by too many vessel types, fragmented spare parts, and inconsistent maintenance practices?

Busniss community also need to know, If MRO is the foundation of readiness, what contract models can realistically incentivize outcomes, availability-based packages, operating-hour-based schemes, or blended approaches, and what institutional reforms would be needed to implement them without creating new rent-seeking channels? Finally, how will foreign grants and capacity-building programs affect domestic industry: do they crowd out acquisition opportunities, or do they stimulate follow-on markets in maintenance, training, integration, and logistics, and what independent readiness auditing mechanisms could ensure the 2045 posture remains measurable rather than symbolic?

These questions matter because they move the conversation from aspiration to implementation. If Indonesia government can answer them with operational data (readiness audits, supply chain mapping, interoperability case studies, and NMSS performance evaluations) then "2045 posture" can evolve from a headline into a credible policy roadmap. That roadmap, in turn, is what makes both public oversight and responsible business participation possible.